



RIPPED: Shingaar theatre in Ludhiana

rising percentage of workers from poorer states like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal.

While the investigators remain clueless, political parties have been quick to indulge in a blame game. For the first time, even the Union Home Ministry blamed the Punjab Police's intelligence wing for not heeding to its warning of terror attacks during the festive season. The police brass, however, rue that the alert lacked specific inputs. Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal defended the state police and declared that the Ludhiana incidents did not indicate the return of terrorism to the border state as the Opposition Congress has termed the incident as yet another example of the failure of the Government on the law and order front. Clearly, the vital issue of internal security remains what it has been blithely reduced to—a political blame game, despite the diabolic spread of terror tentacles.

by Ramesh Vinayak

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: Former Supreme Court judge **Justice Ranjit Singh Sarkaria**, who defined Centre-state relations for over two decades. He had laid down the extent of the Union's powers under Article 356 in the context of the states. He was 91.



WON: The Hero Honda Indian Open Golf tournament by **Jyoti Randhawa**.

He gets a cash prize of Rs 1.96 crore and now has seven Asian titles under his belt.

DIED: Former Karnataka chief minister **S.R. Bommai**. He was 84. His petition against the Centre's dismissal of his government in 1989, helped the courts lay down parameters within which Article 356 can be used.

INAUGURATED: A state-of-the-art **National Tsunami Warning Centre**, which has the capability to detect earthquakes measuring up to six on the Richter scale in the Indian Ocean.

Theatre of Terror

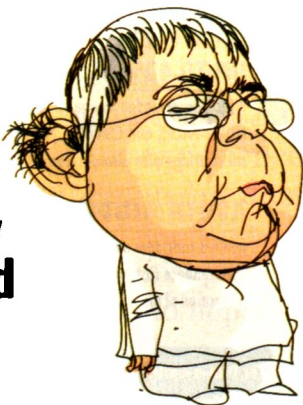
CHANDIGARH Three days after the Ajmer Sharif blast killed two, a sickeningly familiar plot was re-enacted in Ludhiana on October 14 when a powerful explosion rocked a cinema hall killing six and wounding 32 others. The motive, modus operandi and identity of the perpetrators remains elusive to security agencies despite official claims about the blasts being the handiwork of Pakistan-based terror groups.

The blast, caused by a high-grade explosive,

coinciding with Eid and Navratras, has triggered a guessing game among intelligence agencies and a blame game between political parties. The Punjab Police has been quick to name the usual suspects—the dormant and disorganised Punjab militant group Babbar Khalsa and the Khalistan Zindabad Force. They are not ruling out the possibility of migrant population being the target of these attacks. Radical Sikh organisations have been opposing the

VIS-A-VIS LALU PRASAD YADAV Union railway minister versus NITISH KUMAR Bihar chief minister

Those who would bring the largest number of people to the Chetawani rally would be rewarded with a cup.



SAURABH SINGH

There are also a number of snakes in the rally ground. I have asked the district officials to keep anti-venom injections ready.

EPILOGUE: Wonder who is warning whom and about what.